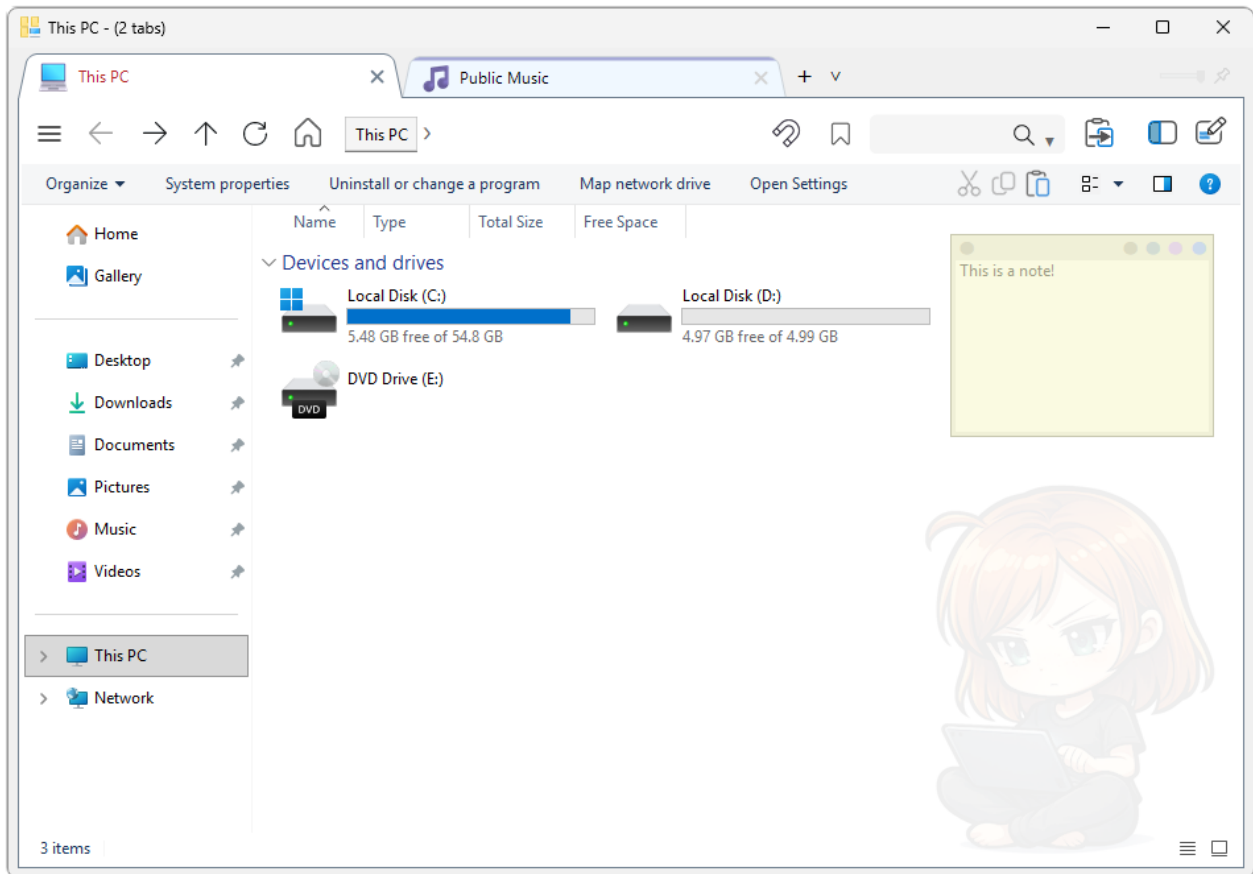


TabExplorer

Version 1.0.2.1

Welcome to TabExplorer!

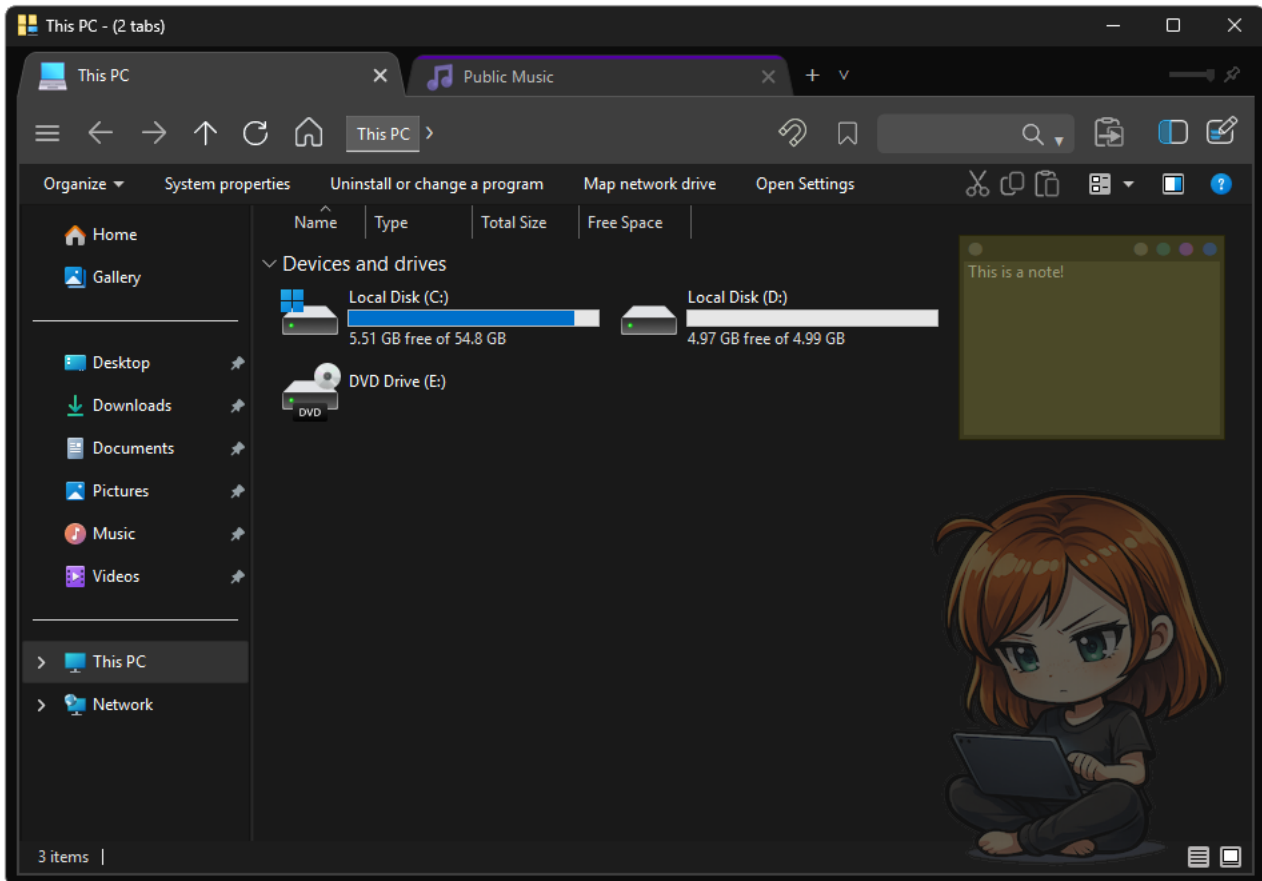


Unlike other file managers, TabExplorer does not replace Windows File Explorer. Instead, it replaces what Microsoft puts around it and what can sometimes become a burden: tabs, menus, buttons, effects...

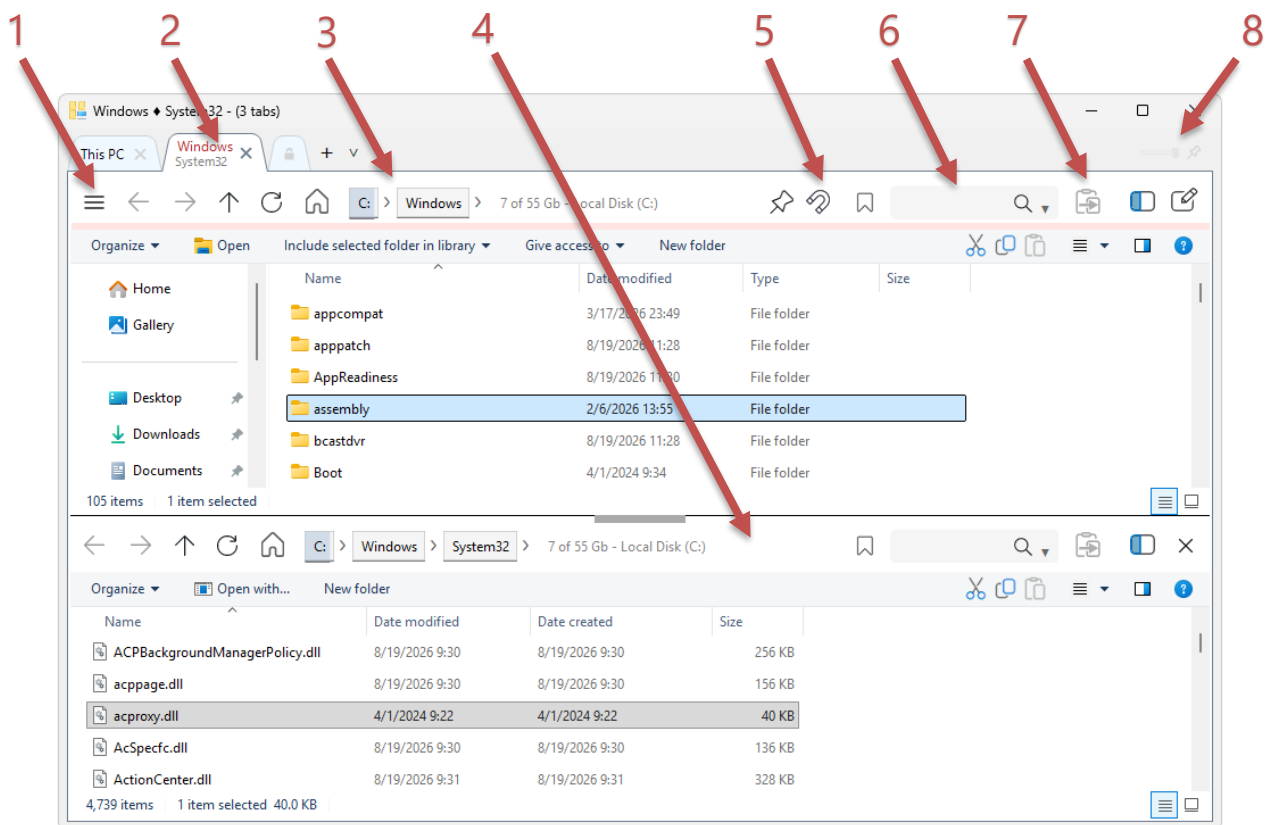
To achieve this, TabExplorer uses Microsoft's own libraries to incorporate file and folder browsing without everything else. The result is a lightweight, portable **program (simply copy it and run it from the** desired folder) that takes up barely 2 MB, uses around 60 MB of RAM and can respond even faster than Windows 11 File Explorer itself.

All of this is achieved without sacrificing native Windows File Explorer, which remains available with all its features and functions and full operating-system integration (and which will continue to update independently and transparently as Microsoft releases Windows patches and revisions).

The advantage of using native File Explorer inside TabExplorer is that it works exactly as Microsoft designed it and behaves in precisely the same way (it even uses the same keyboard shortcuts). TabExplorer therefore only needs to handle the additions and conveniences around it: navigation buttons, tabs, background and color customization, dark mode, search, selection, favorites, a secondary browser on the same screen... all in the most intuitive and straightforward way possible.



The TabExplorer window



As explained above, TabExplorer adds tabs, navigation buttons, customization and an optional secondary browser around the familiar native Windows File Explorer.

1. **The hamburger menu** contains most options (dark mode, customization, run at startup...). The usual navigation **buttons** are also available: previous and next folder (in visit order, with a context menu), up one level, refresh and home.
2. **The tab system** includes its own context menu (open a secondary browser, clone the tab, view recently closed tabs, customize its color...) together with the "+" button for adding tabs and the "v" button for listing and searching them.
3. **The path** is displayed as breadcrumbs, similar to native File Explorer, with each block representing a folder. When available, the free and total space and the device name are shown in gray after the last block.
4. **Secondary browser:** Tabs can optionally be split in two, vertically or horizontally, to display a useful secondary file browser.
5. **Window pin:** This only appears in secondary TabExplorer windows. When enabled, the window will reopen the next time TabExplorer is run.

Native Explorer magnet: When enabled, newly opened native Windows File Explorer windows are detected and closed automatically, and their paths are opened in new tabs. This provides a simple way to make TabExplorer the "default Windows file explorer" without

actually interfering with native File Explorer's operation or integrations, which is usually problematic and not recommended.

Favorites: Saves paths for quick access. Favorites are shared by all TabExplorer windows.

6. **Selection and search box:** Selects items from the files currently displayed. Pressing the magnifying-glass button opens an advanced file search by date, in subfolders, by content, and so on. The "v" button next to the magnifying glass reopens previous searches even after they have been closed; they are retained only until the window itself is closed.

7. **Parallel paste: When** large files, or a large number of files, are copied or moved, TabExplorer may sometimes stop responding until the operation finishes. This button performs the action on a parallel thread so that the interface remains responsive.

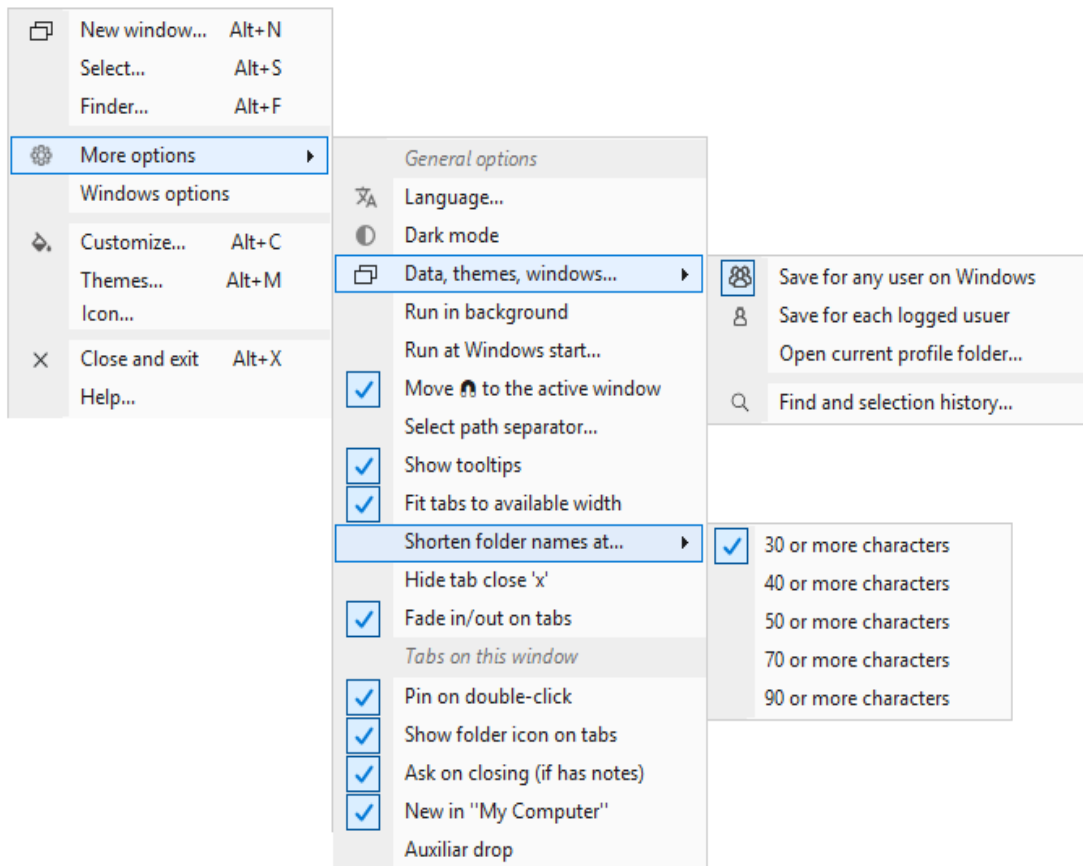
Note: This does not change how files are copied and pasted. Windows will continue to use the configured method, whether it is the default system method or one installed by the user, such as TeraCopy.

8. **Folder tree button, used** to show or hide the tree as needed.

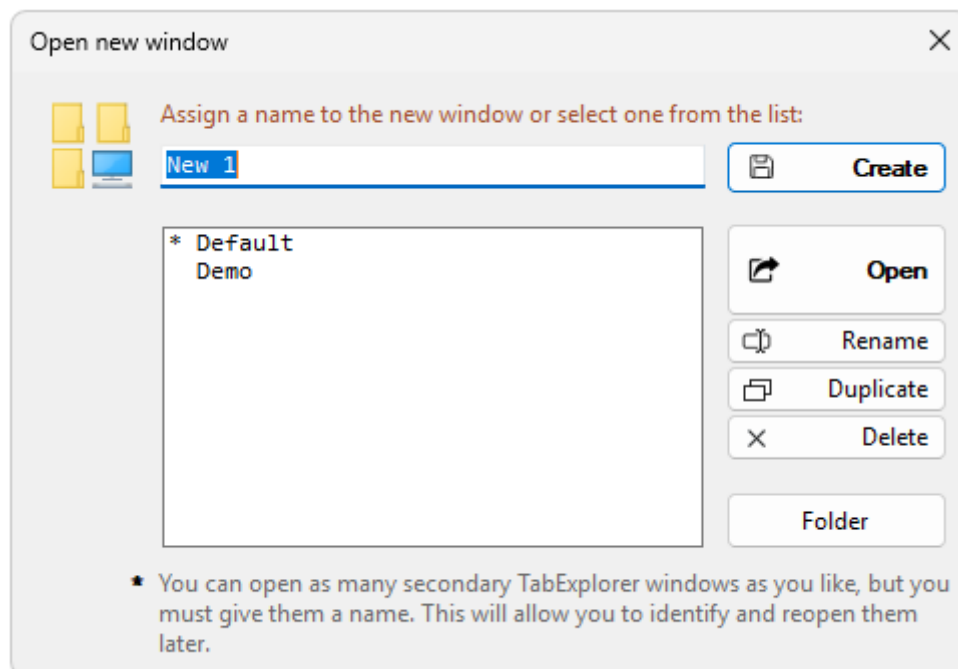
Notes button: Displays a floating note associated with the current tab. Closing a tab that contains notes also removes those notes.

Opacity selector and always-on-top pin, located above the previous two buttons: These change the window's opacity and keep it above all other Windows windows. Both settings remain in effect until the window is closed.

Options menu



New window



Any number of TabExplorer windows can be opened in addition to the initial window, called "Default". The only requirement is that the other windows have names so they can be saved (each window is associated with an INI data file), reopened at any time and restored to their previous state. In the list of available windows, an asterisk identifies those that are currently open.

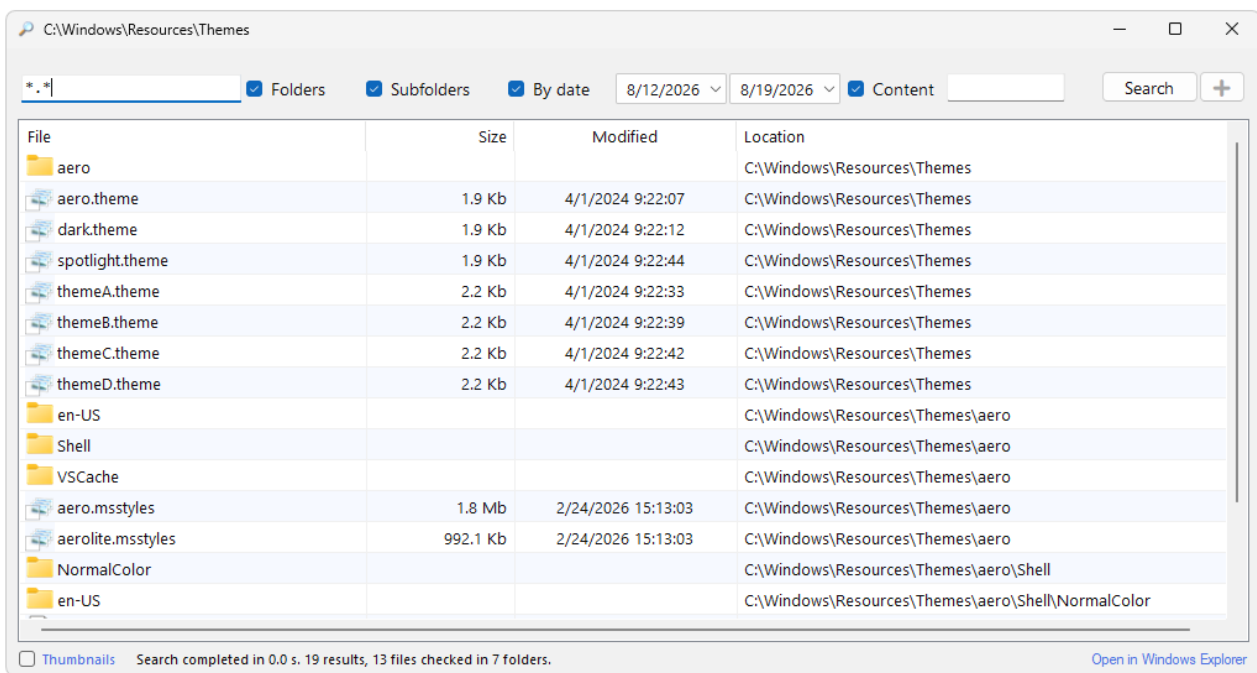
The main "Default" window always opens first, followed by any windows whose window pin has been enabled.

Select

The Select **option** enters file-selection mode (also available with F3). See later for more details.

Finder

Opens a search window at the current path. It can find files or folders by using wildcards, dates, recursive subfolder searches, file contents, and more. Several searches can be opened and revisited at any time until the window is closed.



More options

Language

- Changes the language of TabExplorer's menus and options. File Explorer itself continues to use the language selected in Windows. Custom languages can be created by using the text files with the "LNG" extension as templates.



Dark mode

- Join the Dark Side of TabExplorer!

Data, themes, windows

- **Save for any Windows user: All windows,** themes and other data are saved in the "anyUser" folder *inside* the folder from which TabExplorer is run.
- **Save per signed-in user:** The configuration is saved in a folder named after the signed-in Windows user, always within the TabExplorer folder to ensure full portability.
- **Selection and search history:** Edits the contextual histories displayed when typing in certain selection or search boxes.

Run in background

- When a window is closed, it remains hidden in the background. An icon in the notification area next to the clock can be used to return to it.

Run at Windows startup

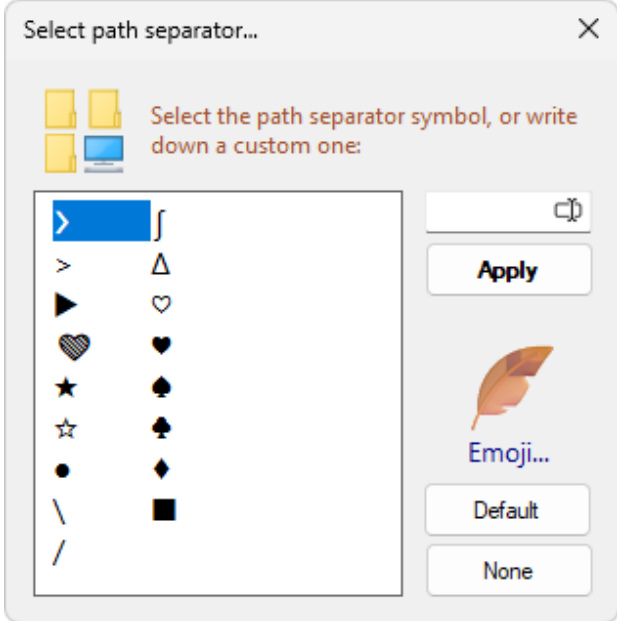
- Starts TabExplorer automatically when Windows session begins.

Move magnet to the active window

- If the native Explorer magnet is enabled, it follows whichever TabExplorer window is active so that newly opened native Explorer windows are captured there. If the magnet is not enabled, this option will have any effect at all.

Choose path separator

- Replaces the ">" symbol between path blocks with another symbol or with an emoji from the Windows built-in set.



Show tooltips

- Enables or disables the tooltips displayed when the pointer rests on a button.

Fit tabs to available width

- Tabs will become wider when plenty of space is available, or narrower when there are more tabs than can be displayed (avoiding the need to scroll).

Shorten names

- Sets the number of characters shown before longer folder names are shortened, preventing absurdly wide tabs.

Hide “x”

- Hides tab close buttons to save space. Tabs must then be closed from the context menu or with the keyboard shortcut.

Animation between tabs

- A brief fade-in and *fade-out effect* when switching tabs, used to avoid flicker and abrupt changes.

Pin on double-click

- Allows a tab to be pinned or unpinned by double-clicking it. If disabled, this must be done through the context menu.

Show folder icon on tabs

- When enabled, this displays the icon of the folder being browsed to the left of each tab. When disabled, the icon is hidden completely unless an emoji has been selected, in which case it will remain visible.

Ask before closing (if there is a note)

- Requests confirmation before closing a tab that contains notes.

New in This PC

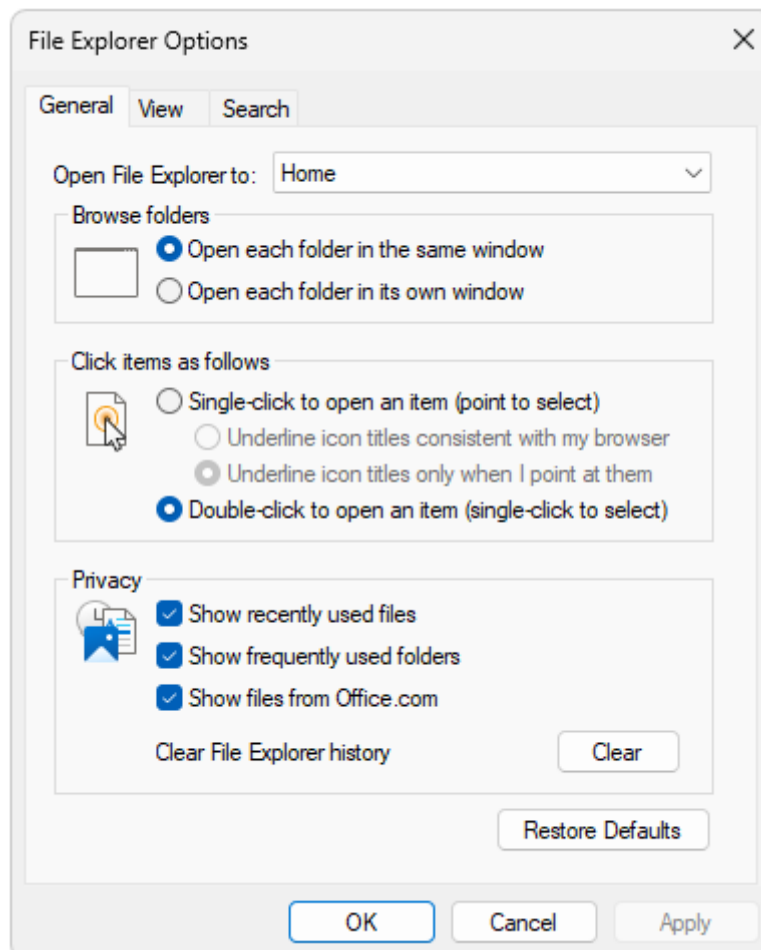
- New tabs open in “This PC” instead of C:\.

Auxiliary Drop

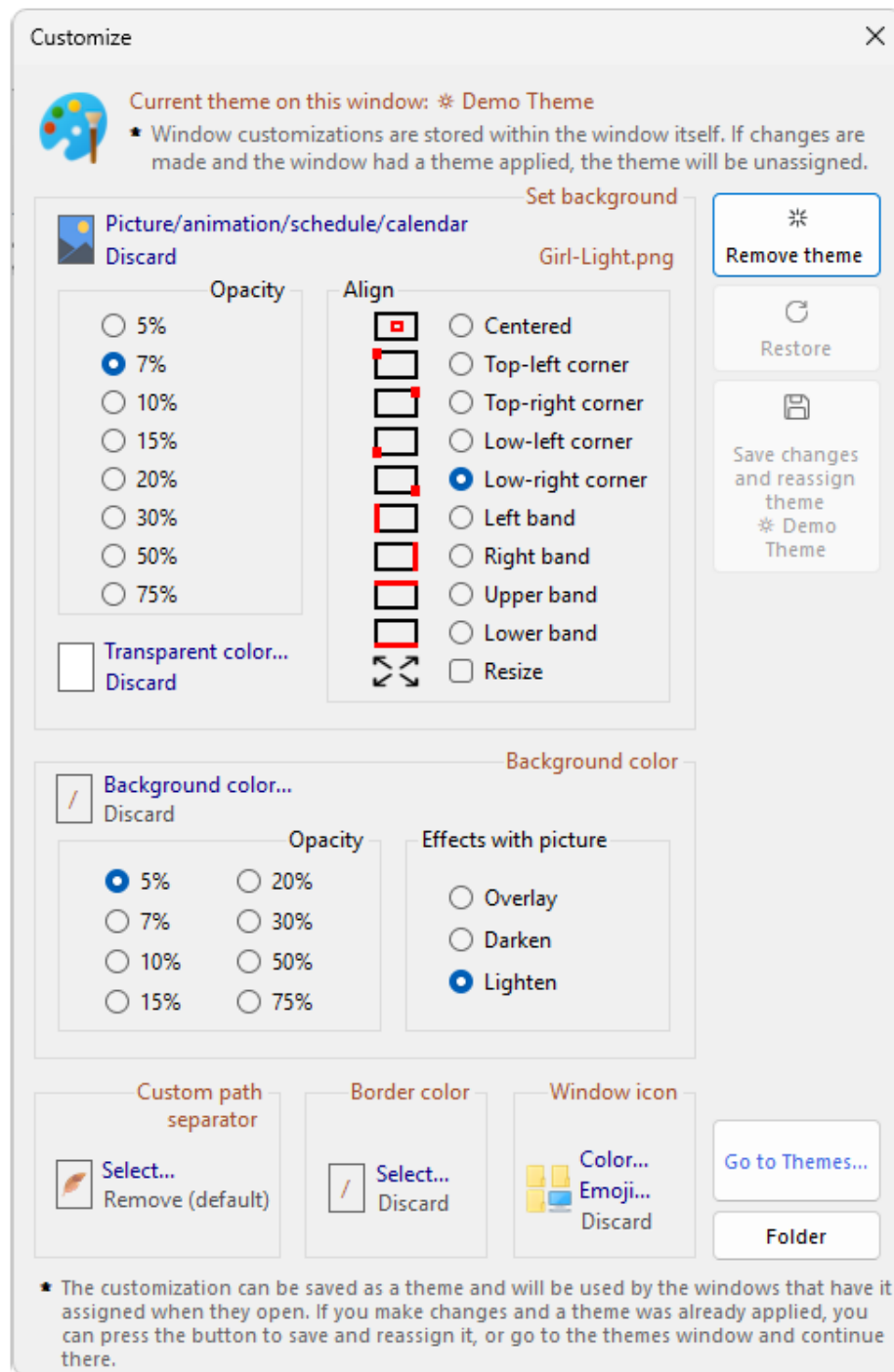
- Displays a new button next to Parallel Paste. Pressing it opens an independent mini browser at the current folder, onto which files can be dragged from another location to copy or move them. This drag-and-drop window prevents lengthy operations from blocking TabExplorer's main window—for example, dragging large files from inside a compressed archive or from its application's own window, such as WinRAR or 7-Zip.

Windows options

Simply opens the native Folder Options screen in Windows Control Panel. Any changes made there apply to native Windows File Explorer and therefore to the browser displayed in TabExplorer.



Customize

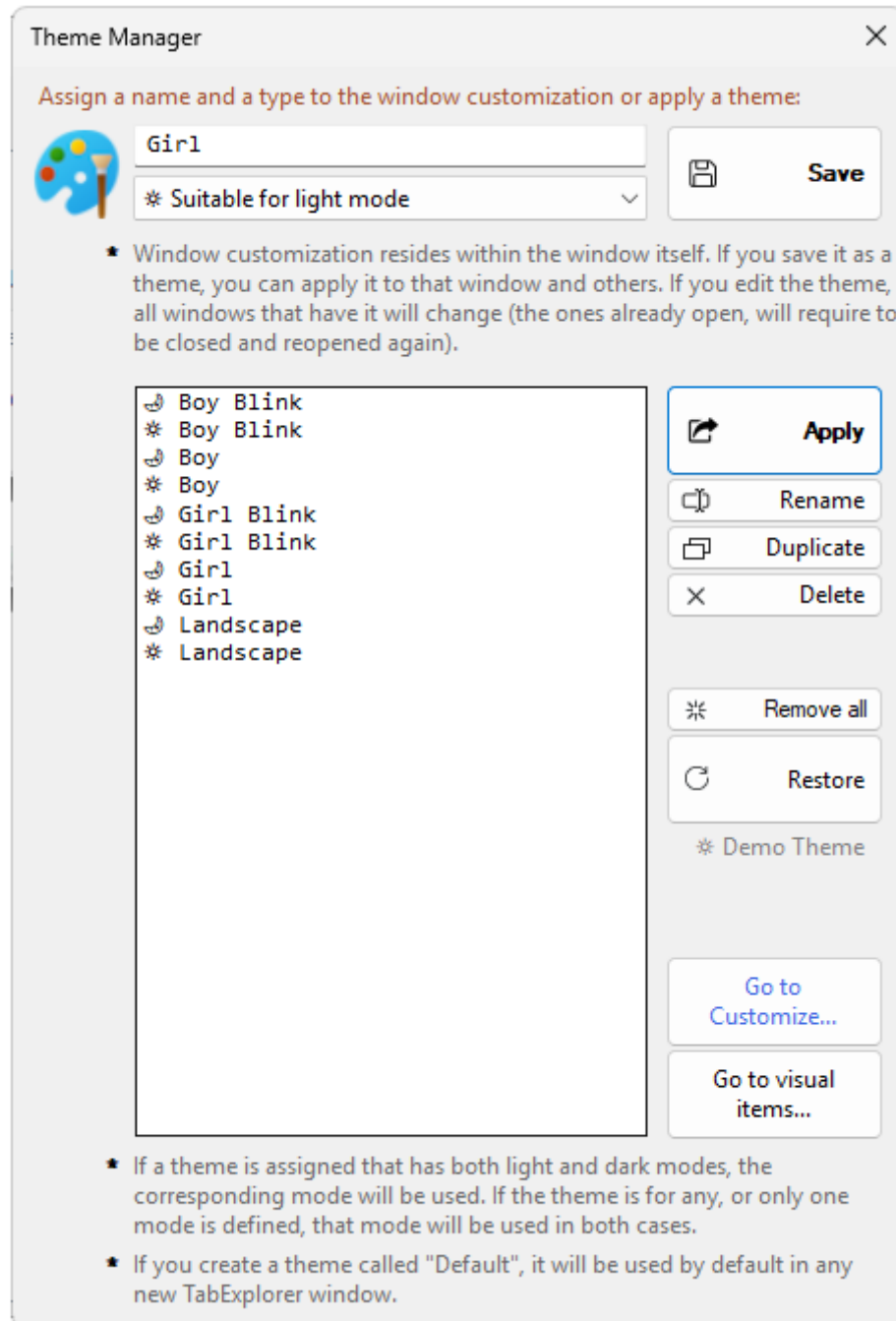


The **customization screen** sets a background **image for the current window, like** a skin, *with* the chosen opacity and tint. It can be a photograph, a company logo, a mascot, and so on. If a transparency color is selected, parts of the image painted in that color become transparent. A PNG's own transparency is always applied in addition to the selected setting.

A tint color can also be **applied, either** added to the image or used as a color overlay. The window **icon, border color** and **path separator** can **also** be changed. The **icon** can also be changed as well with an emoji.

As an experimental feature in this version, an animation can be used instead of an image. Animations and images can also be scheduled throughout the day or across the entire year. See the Animations section at the end of this **document** for more information.

Themes

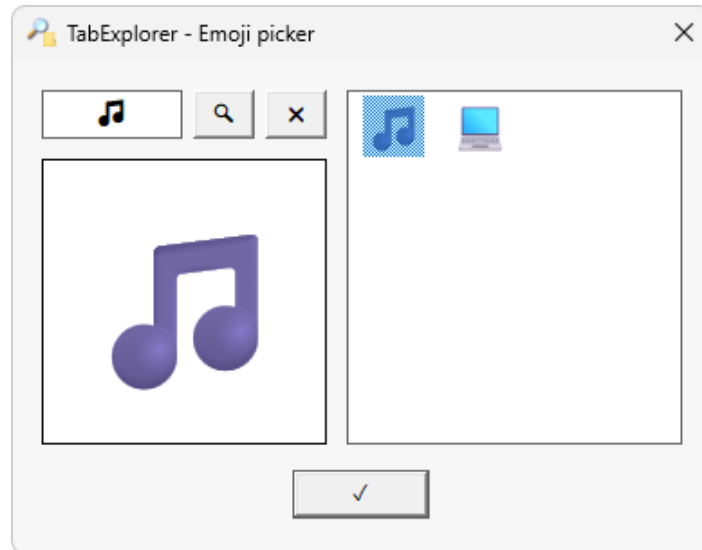


The **Themes screen** assigns a name to the current window customization and saves it so that it can be applied to any other TabExplorer window.

When saving a theme, it can be marked as suitable for light mode, dark mode or either mode. Both versions must have the same name; this creates “paired themes” that TabExplorer selects automatically according to the current light or dark mode.

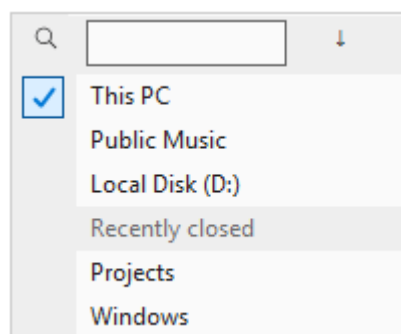
In addition, a theme saved with the name “Default” is applied to new TabExplorer windows by default. This can be used, for example, to display a company logo at all times.

Icon



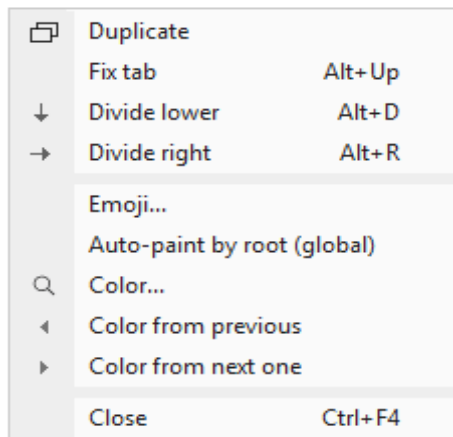
The emoji picker lets you use any emoji available in Windows as the window icon, as well as supported letters, numbers and Unicode characters. The most recently used ones are shown on the right. For the change to take effect, the Windows taskbar must be configured either not to combine icons or to combine them only when the taskbar is full. This picker is also used elsewhere in the program, for example to choose a tab icon or the path separator. Emojis are saved in TabExplorer’s Emojis folder as they are used as PNG pictures, so they do not need to be generated each time.

Open and recent tabs menu



This menu opens by pressing the “v” icon next to the “+” tab button or by using its keyboard shortcut. It lists currently open tabs and tabs closed recently during the session. Its search box can search by name or path and also includes tabs with a secondary browser.

Tab context menu



Duplicate

Duplicates the current tab in a new tab. The new tab is identical, including its path, color, secondary browser, customization and notes.

Pin

(Also available by double-clicking, when enabled.) The tab becomes narrower, displays a padlock icon and cannot be closed unless this menu option is selected explicitly.

Split down / split right

Splits the tab horizontally or vertically and adds a secondary file browser, making it easy to view and work between two different folders without switching tabs.

Send tab to...

When more than one TabExplorer window is open, this option is available as a submenu. Selecting a window sends the current tab there. A tab can also be dragged onto another open window to move it there, or outside the window to open it in a new window.

Emoji

Sets an emoji as icon for the current tab, from the Windows' built-in set.

Color

Chooses a color to highlight the top of a tab so that several tabs can be grouped visually. This option is unavailable when Auto-paint by root is enabled.

Color from previous/next tab

Applies the color of the tab adjacent to the current tab. These options are unavailable when Auto-paint by root is enabled.

Auto-paint by root

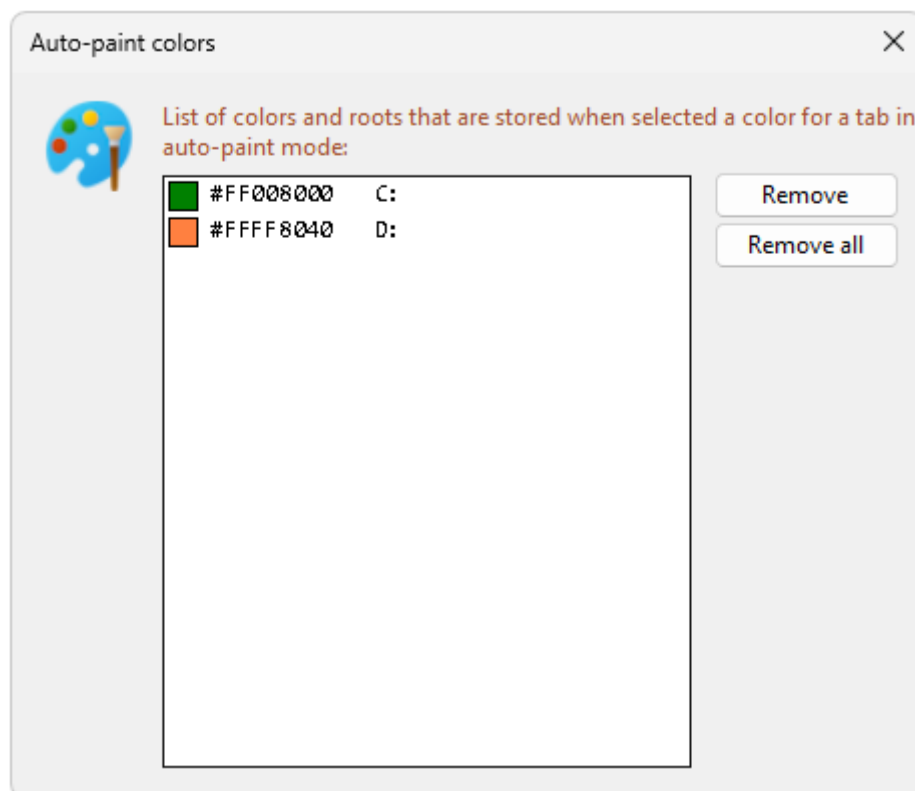
While this option is active, colors chosen individually for tabs are no longer used, although they are not lost. Instead, a global color set is applied according to the location's root, across every tab in every open window.

How does it work? A color selected for one tab is applied to every tab whose path has the same root. For example, if blue is selected for a folder on drive C:, every TabExplorer tab on drive C: in every window will use that color. This makes it possible to define global colors by location.

The root that determines the color cannot currently be configured.

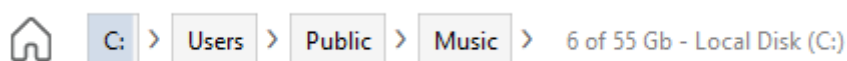
When this option is enabled, the previous two options disappear and the following option is shown instead.

Auto-paint colors by root



Available only when the previous option has been selected. This screen lists the colors assigned so far and allows them to be removed if desired.

The current path

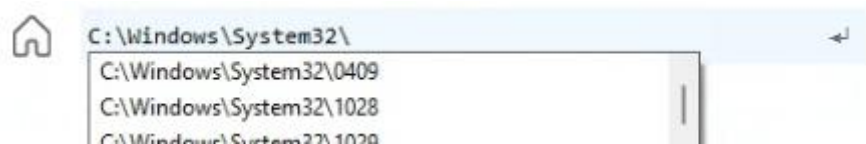


The current path is displayed **as blocks, or breadcrumbs**, in a way similar to native File Explorer. Each block represents one folder level. The first block graphically indicates the drive's used space in darker gray and available space in lighter gray. After the last block, the available and total space and the volume label are also displayed when that information is available.

Clicking the first block goes directly to the drive root; clicking an intermediate block goes to that particular folder level.

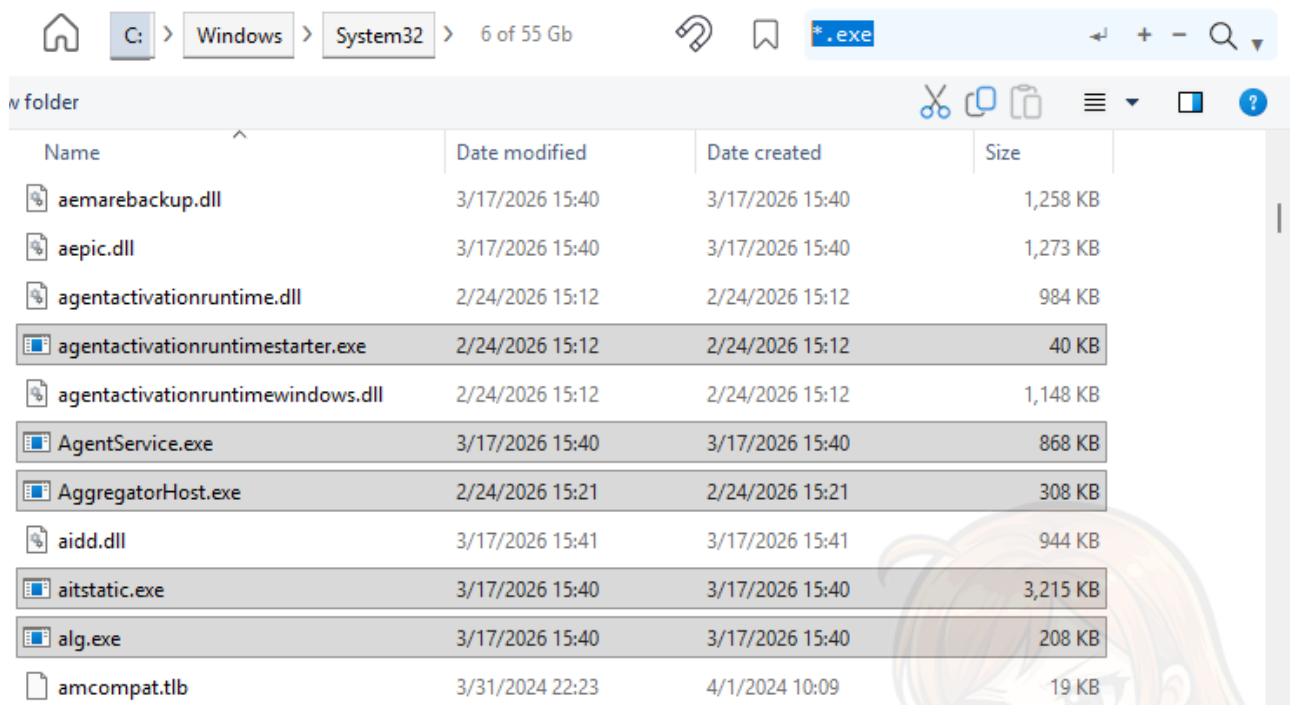
Clicking the separator between blocks displays a menu containing the subfolders at that level, if any.

Right-clicking a block enters typing mode and selects the path from that block onward. Clicking anywhere else enters normal typing mode. As text is entered, a context menu displays any matching subfolders.



As in native File Explorer, certain special commands can also be entered, such as "cmd", "notepad" or a URL.

File selection



This box selects files by using the usual wildcards (? and *). In the example, *.exe has selected every file with that extension.

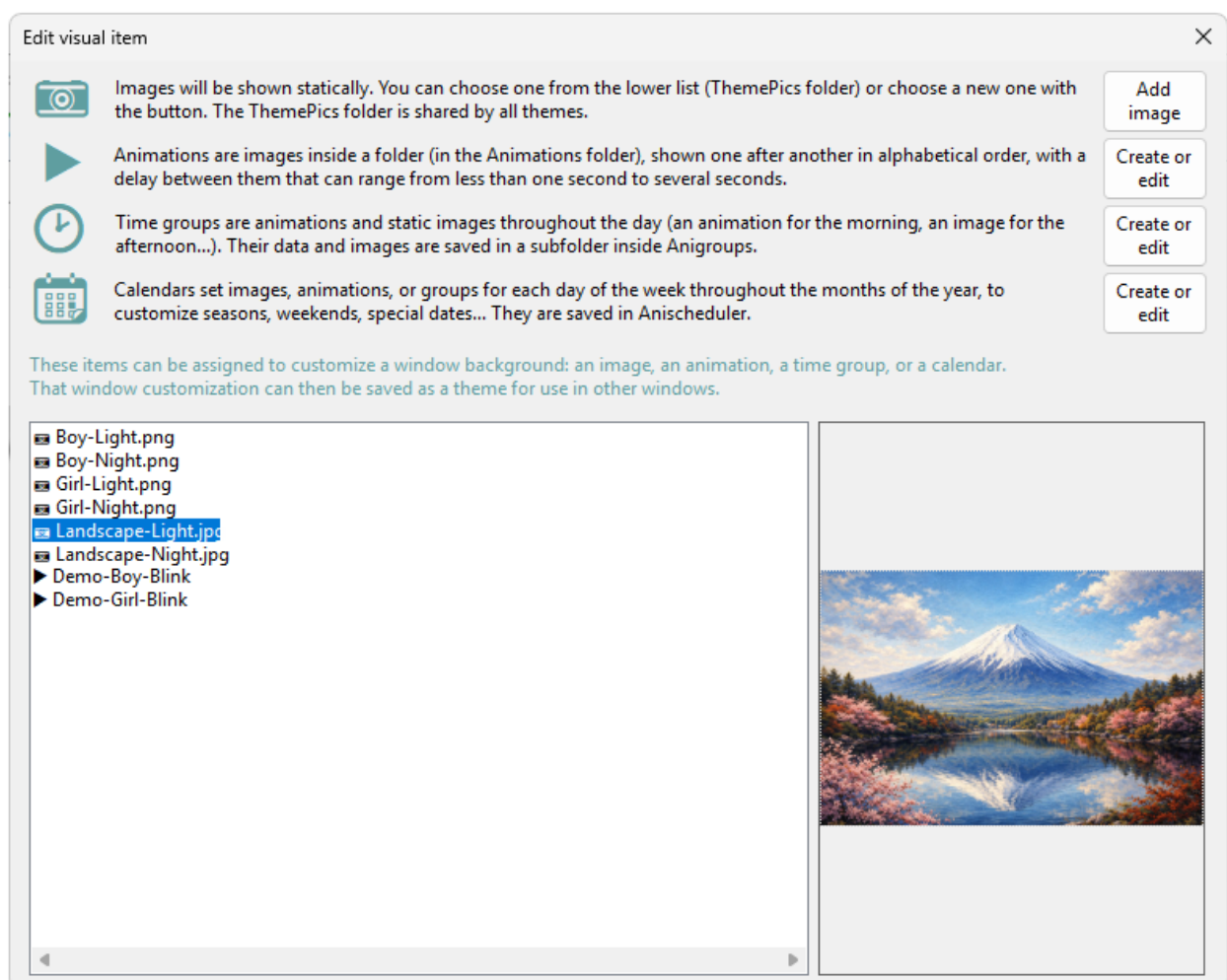
Note: File extensions can be shown or hidden on the native File Explorer Folder Options screen, along with options such as hiding protected operating-system files, showing hidden files and displaying compressed files in a different color.

- If + is selected and a different filter is applied, the results are added to the current selection.
- If - is selected and a different filter is applied, the results are removed from the current selection.
- If neither option is selected and a different filter is applied, the previous selection is discarded and the new results are selected.

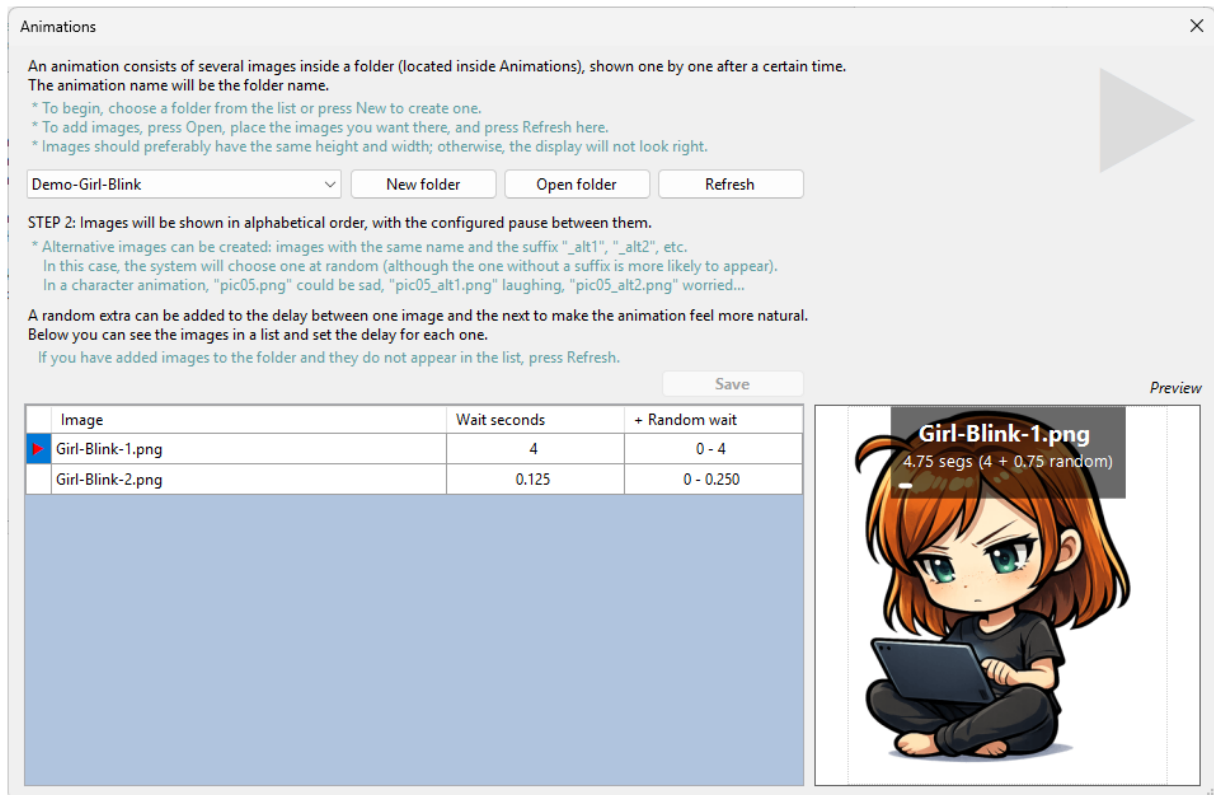
The file finder (magnifying glass) and previous searches ("v" button) can also be accessed here.

Animations (experimental)

Version 1.0.2.0 introduces **experimental support** for displaying animations instead of static images as the TabExplorer background. The customization image selector has therefore been redesigned to offer four different types of visual item:



Animations



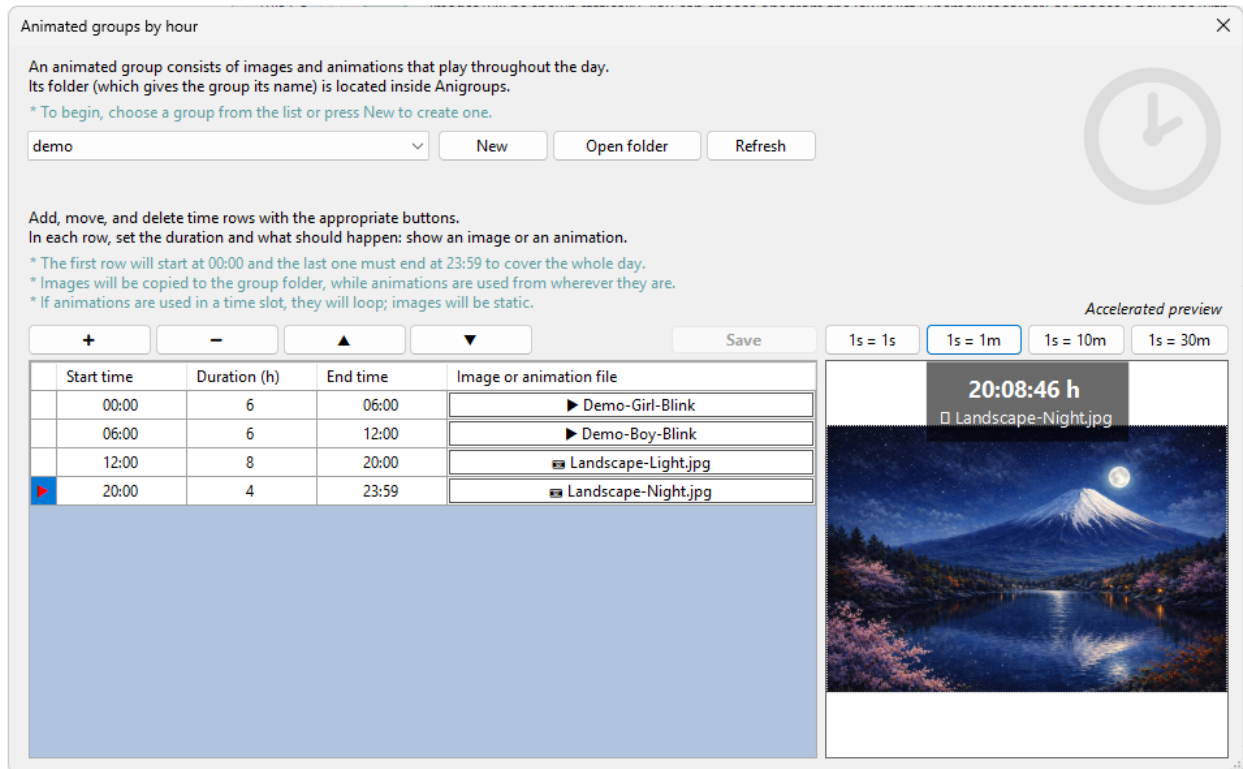
Animations are stored in a **new** "Animations" folder inside the user profile. Each subfolder is an animation and contains its images. The images play repeatedly in alphabetical order, exactly as listed in File Explorer.

The editor displays the images in the selected animation and allows the delay between them and an optional random factor to be set, making effects such as blinking look more natural.

To rename or delete an animation, simply rename or delete its folder. Be **careful: if the animation** is used by other items or windows, it will no longer be available to them.

To duplicate an animation, copy and paste its folder under another name. Its contents do not need to be changed; only the folder name matters.

Animated groups by hour



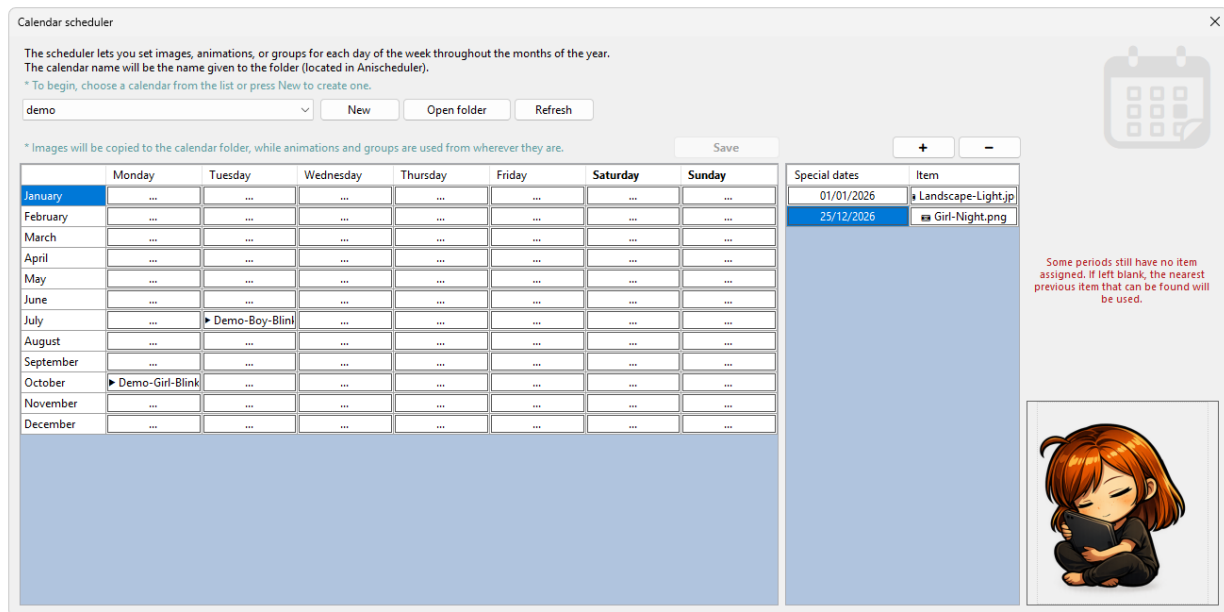
These are stored in a new **"Anigroups"** folder inside the user profile. Each subfolder is a group of images or animations that play at different times of day. The editor adds time ranges and assigns either a static image or an existing animation to each one. For example, one animation might play in the morning, another at midday, a static image in the afternoon and another item at night.

Images used by a group are copied into the group's folder, but animations remain in their original locations. If an animation used by one or more groups is changed, those groups automatically display the updated animation. If it is deleted or renamed, however, the groups will no longer find it and will fail.

To rename or delete a group, simply rename or delete its folder. Be **careful: if the group is** used by other items or windows, it will no longer be available to them.

To duplicate a group, copy and paste its folder under another name. Its contents do not need to be changed; only the folder name matters.

Annual calendar



Calendars are stored in a new **"Anischeduler"** folder inside the user profile. Each subfolder is a schedule covering every day of the week throughout all twelve months.

It defines what will play on each Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, and so on in every month. Assigning groups makes it possible to customize the whole year very precisely, and user-defined special dates such as birthdays, holidays and events are also supported.

As before, images are copied into the calendar folder, while animations and groups are referenced at their existing locations. If an animation or group used by one or more calendars changes, those calendars automatically display the updated content. If it is deleted or renamed, however, they will no longer find it and will fail.

To rename or delete a calendar, simply rename or delete its folder. Be **careful: if the calendar** is used by other items or windows, it will no longer be available to them.

To duplicate a calendar, copy and paste its folder under another name. Its contents do not need to be changed; only the folder name matters.

How do they work?

Animations, groups and **calendars** work **much** more **simply** than they might appear. Whenever an image is needed, the theme manager asks which image should be displayed:

- For an animation, if the required interval has elapsed, it obtains the next image.
- For a group, the PC time determines the current time range and the item assigned to it. That item is then queried in the same way until the image to display is obtained.

- For a calendar, the current weekday and month are also taken into account. Once they have been determined, the assigned item is obtained and queried in one of the ways described above.

In every case, the final result is an image to which the window's chosen transparency, tint and other settings are applied.

One consideration: Time ranges may be left empty. When this happens, the theme manager searches for the most recent available content—looking “back in time” until it finds something valid—and displays it.

Warning: The resources consumed by animations are directly proportional to the size of their images. Small images such as mascots and logos have almost no impact. Large, detailed photographs can be expensive to load and should be used in animations whose changes are spaced widely apart, such as landscapes whose details change very slowly over several hours.

There is also an undocumented option to modify the item currently playing from outside TabExplorer, for example with Notepad. If the appropriate INI file is edited, the animation engine follows its new value the next time it checks what to display. The same applies when an image used by an animation is replaced. INI files are read and cached in memory, but they are read again when their modification date shows that they have changed. Images, on the other hand, are loaded once, retained until no longer needed and reloaded when needed again. Such changes may therefore not be immediate: the old image may remain visible in animations with very long intervals, in groups with a static image assigned to a long time range, in a calendar when the current day uses a group or static image, or with classic static backgrounds, which are read only once. Advanced users can choose how to make these external or dynamic modifications and which tools to use.

Requirements



Windows 10 or later

Microsoft .NET Framework 4.8, which is normally preinstalled with Windows.